the lowest common denominator, that too with deep deference to vested interests. This then necessitates arrangements of convenience to assert themselves.

Such minilateralism is practised in different combinations on various issues. As it grows, a larger culture of plurilateralism has begun to emerge. In itself, this is not entirely new. Earlier, a regional explanation provided a basis for working together. So, we had the EU, ASEAN, SAARC, GCC, etc., where proximity was the foundational basis for shared activities. We also saw nations collaborating on specific issues like maritime security, counter-terrorism, export controls, non-proliferation and climate change. It could even be an effort to influence rebalancing and advance multipolarity. And it went beyond the compulsions of geography. BRICS is one case in point, where four continents were reflected in one membership.

The difference now is that such groupings can become broader in their agenda, while also more purposeful in their working. The Quad, in that sense, is a sign of such changing times. What makes this format more appealing is that it has much lower overhead costs. There are no treaties, obligations, establishments or even disciplines that come with better relationships. It would seem that frugality is also a virtue now in the area of diplomacy.

When it comes to multipolarity, it is essential that we do not judge this complicated world by a simple yardstick. The phenomenon itself expresses a range of credible powers, whose interplay influences the global outcome. But the fact is that nations have acquired such differential capabilities that they perform in an increasingly domain-specific manner. Consider how this appears from the perspective of a nation like India. Political multipolarity has an obvious set of players, among them the P-5 nations of the UNSC, collectives like the EU and ASEAN, and those individual states that are regionally important. Economic multipolarity, however, looks very different because it is a product of some other factors. India’s most substantial trade accounts are the hubs of the EU, the US, China, the Gulf and ASEAN. The equation stacks up still more differently in the case of energy. The key partners on this score are Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Russia, UAE and the US. Viewed from the technology perspective, the answers would move much more in the direction of Western economies. When it comes to mobility and skills, the Gulf obviously has to be given its due weight, but it is the West that provides more value addition.